

The Paradox of Ontological Security in Far-right Narratives and the Securitisation of Identified Alterities: the Cases of Spain and Italy

Abstract:

Nationalistic far-right discourse promises to restore and defend the nation against identified alterities, which they blame for a supposed lost “national authenticity”. An analysis of the paradoxical claims of the Italian and Spanish far-right parties in 2022 and 2023 examines how discourses of ontological insecurities are presented as threats posed by alterities to national majorities. The article claims that sometimes these discourses are mixed with securitization moves, but at times there is evident separation between the two processes. Among what the far-right identifies as alterities, political and cultural adversaries are blamed for national ontological insecurity: the US Liberal system, religious minorities, the EU, and migration. The findings illustrate that the far-right uses a catch-all strategy on all these themes through the usage of paradoxical claims in their discourse. Through the analysis, it becomes evident that the scapegoating of alterities is crucial to identify when ontological insecurity is indeed connected to the spiralling of the securitization process and particularly to how it allows the far-right to prosper.

Keywords: Ontological security; Securitization; Alterities; Majorities; Paradoxical claims; Narratives.

Introduction

The rise of the far-right has become a contemporary growing concern across the European Union for all those who advocate and enjoy freedoms, diversity and civic liberties. Far-right movements and parties have capitalized on the mounting sense of social anxiety and insecurity among Europeans (Author 1, 2017). Such uneasiness has broadened as a consequence of a series of dramatic events, including the financial crisis of 2008 and the COVID pandemic in 2020 (Mudde, 2019; Ivaldi, 2019). Some authors (Kinnvall *et al*, 2018; Brack, 2021; Wodak, 2022) claim that these severe situations have increased the feelings of ontological insecurity (Giddens, 1991) of the citizens of the European Union, raising doubts, uncertainty and confusion about its self-preservation, and continuity. The Ontological Security Theory (OST) literature reflects on the consequences for collective security processes of the experience of anxiety generated by the inherent precariousness of the human condition. Being aware of their finiteness entails for humans a constant, continued search of security. As Berenskötter (2020) noted, this search for “becoming secure” can never be satisfied for humans’ own condition. Therefore, it entails what he calls an *anxiety paradox*. We consider that the far-right exploits and contributes to this anxiety paradox with their narratives. However, we claim that it is still important to be able to differentiate between the use of ontological(in)security and the start of a process of securitization. The two elements can definitely overlap as different studies have proven (Bonansinga, 2021; Croft, 2012; Browning and Joenniemi, 2016). However, it is not a *sine*

qua non: the two processes can still be differentiated analytically. This can prove crucial to understand when insecurities can spiral through securitization.

When referring to far-right political movements, ideas, and political parties such as Vox and Fratelli d'Italia, this article uses the umbrella term “far-right” according to the definition of political scientist Cas Mudde, which can be validly used by political scientists, contemporary historians, and scholars of international relations (Campos, 2023; Pirro, 2022). Mudde clarifies that he is not concerned with right-wing “mainstream” parties but with those positioned to the right of them, specifically anti-system parties that oppose many principles of liberal democracy. Central to Mudde's definition is nativism, which underscores the far-right's anti-immigrant stance and its “us versus them” dynamic. Mudde categorizes far-right political parties into two subgroups: the extreme right, which rejects the core essence of democracy and aims to establish authoritarian regimes hostile towards pluralism and equality, and the radical right. However, this article focuses only on the radical right, exemplified by parties like Vox and Fratelli d'Italia, which participate in democratic processes but oppose fundamental elements of democracy such as “minority rights, rule of law, and separation of powers” (Mudde, 2019: p.7).

In line with OST theory, we consider that far-right parties essentialize who a European is and freeze its “being” in a supposed perennial entity that has neither existed nor ever become possible. By manipulating anxiety coping mechanisms of the Self, they translate the intrinsic human condition of precariousness into a feeling of external threat, scapegoating “others”. Identified alterities, intended as what alters -according to the nationalistic political discourse- the supposed essence of the nation, are under attack in far-right narratives as those responsible for threatening the political and cultural core of a given majority. In such a way, it is also possible to understand why minorities and migrants are among the most frequently targeted others.

With an in-depth analysis of the far-right in Italy and Spain, we aim to expand the field started by those studies (Bonansinga, 2021 and 2022; Croft, 2012; Browning and Joenniemi, 2016; Kurylo, 2020) that have combined the securitization debate and the OST. With the current work, we propose a methodology to discern when these two processes – the securitization and the ontological (in)security – happen concurrently or not. This effort is considered a necessary one because of the recent developments within the securitization debate of the *spiralling theory* (Author 1, 2017; Author and Léonard, 2023). The *spiralling theory* highlights that prejudice is both at the start and at the reinforcement of a securitization process through the scapegoating of alterities. The discriminatory accounts about migrants and migration – despite being often a faulty consequence of prejudicial attitudes and ideas – can spiral the social construction of the migration-crime nexus: prejudicial narratives of migration become *self-fulfilling stories*. As a result, the securitization does not show a linear development but a spiralling one (Author 1, 2022a; Bello and Léonard, 20223). The professionals of the scapegoating, such as the far right (but also other forms of religious and political extremisms), exploit the dynamics of the spiralling securitization. Therefore, for the spiralling of the social construction of migrants as threats, the securitization is a *sine qua non* element. Instead, the ontological security alone would not contribute to the spiralling. It must be accompanied by a securitization process to entail an escalating process of constructing alterities as threats.

Methodologically, among the discursive strategies used by the professionals of the scapegoating, paradoxical claims have been initially identified as some specific types of narratives used in the so-called “refugee crisis” of 2015 (Author 1, 2017). The analysis presented here innovates the literature that combines the ST and the OST by focusing on the role of paradoxical claims, as a specific method used by the professionals of scapegoating to make securitization processes spiral in combination with the exploitation of ontological (in)security. This method allows to differentiate when ontological security and securitization overlap from when, instead, ontological security exists without and independently from the securitization process.

In such a framework, this work examines how present-day far-right manipulates Selves’ feeling of ontological (in)security with a variety of paradoxical narratives about the differences. Empirically, it investigates the contemporary far-right discourse in Italy and Spain focusing on both Fratelli d’Italia’s and Vox’s paradoxical claims that emerged in their narratives in the past two years (2022-2023). Therefore, the current study offers both theoretical advancements and methodological innovation. Theoretically, it does so by incorporating in the debate combining the OST and the ST, reflections from the spiralling theory. Methodologically, it contributes to innovating the literature by examining the contemporary far-right’s rhetorical use of paradoxical claims that capitalise on people’s unease by examining whether far-right’s parties in Italy and Spain in recent years use OS in combination with securitization or not.

Bridging Ontological Security and the Spiralling of the Securitization

The combination of the lenses of OST and the ST has contemplated the foundational roles that narratives play in the ontological security of individuals and collectives, often based on the social construction of others as threats (Croft, 2012; Browning and Joenniemi, 2016). OST illustrates the importance of biographical narratives and how discourses employ politics of fear through the creation of external threats to the self (Steele, 2005; Kinnvall, 2017; Subotić, 2016; Rumelili, 2015; Steele, 2008; Herrington, 2013; Berenskötter, 2014, 2020). As highlighted initially by Croft (2012) and then by few other studies (Bonansinga, 2022a and 2022b; Browning and Joenniemi, 2016; Kurylo, 2020), OST importantly overlaps with the securitization debate (Buzan, 1991; Huysmans, 2006; Bourbeau, 2011, Lazaridis and Wadia, 2015; Author 1, 2017 and 2022a), which focuses on the construction of others as security threats. However, there have been recent developments in the securitization debate that have not been encompassed yet in this line of study. We consider that this discussion deserves space as it explains some distinctive features of the role of different discursive techniques – and in particular paradoxical claims – they can use to securitize an issue. We will proceed to first illustrate the recent developments in ST and then discuss its overlap with the OST. This will allow us to depict how the analysis of paradoxical claims can contribute to examining the far-right’s exploitation of ontological (in)security in combination or not with a securitization process.

The anxiety paradox is critical to understanding the far-right’s securitization strategies. It demonstrates how, by promoting the belief in an existential need for ontological security, far-right actors engage in actions that paradoxically sustain a continuous state of insecurity. This sustained insecurity legitimizes further securitization actions, creating a spiraling effect where narratives of threats need to be continuously constructed and

reinforced. Following up on the broader debate of how issues can be securitized via *speech-acts* in the field of international security (Buzan, 1991), Huysmans has highlighted how shifting the governance of migration from the economic and social domain to the security one, has socially constructed a migration-crime nexus (2000). The politics of fear is consequently at the foundation of the social construction of others as a threat (Huysmans, 2006). Not surprisingly, then, such a situation has expanded after 9/11 (Bourbeau, 2011; Lazaridis and Wadia, 2015). As Huysmans illustrates, in periods of social insecurities, these dynamics are accentuated: securitization both exacerbates the challenges that migrants face and amplifies their stigmatization within the public sphere (Huysmans, 2000). The theory of the spiralling of securitization, presented more recently, has proven that a self-perpetuating cycle of initial prejudices can take place with the securitization (Author 1, 2017 and 2022a). Such advancement in the literature shows that the securitization of migration does not follow a linear development but can actually spiral particularly because of the role that prejudice plays both at the start of the process and in its self-fulfilment. At the start of the process, prejudicial cognitions allow the securitization to happen in the first place. However, once it has taken place, the social construction of migrants as threats also self-fulfils the initial prejudice: when migrants are discriminated in extreme ways, including living in prison-like conditions, the migration-crime nexus can difficultly be avoided. So, the prejudicial ideas of the “natives” are self-fulfilled and create new reasons and discursive strategies to securitize migrants further. The securitization process thence spirals, which is to say that it creates new overlapping cycles of insecurities (Author 1, 2017, 2022a; Author 1 and Léonard, 2023).

Therefore, while in the initial debate, securitization studies have mainly focused on the role of *speech-acts* (Buzan and Weaver, 1991), *governmentalities* (Bigo, 2001) and *practices* (Balzacq, 2006), recent work has particularly emphasized the role of narratives in the securitization of others (Author 1, 2022a; Léonard and Kaunert, 2022). The narratives are different from speech-acts: speech-acts need an audience that accepts those speech-acts as true in order to have an effect and effectively securitize an issue (Balzacq, 2006). Instead, recent studies of the securitization of migration have proven that narratives – differently from speech-acts – do not need to be accepted but they have the effect of impressing the audience. They stick in the audience’s memories. Even if not believed in the first place, these narratives might have an effect later on. The key is their repetition in several accounts in networking circles, where the relation of trust matters (Author 1, 2022b). We see this as the reason why contributions bridging ST and OST talk in terms of narratives and not in terms of *speech-acts* when referring to the ontological insecurities created for those groups identified as threats (Croft, 2012; Bonansinga, 2021 and 2022; Browning and Joenniemi, 2016; Kurylo, 2022; Määlkso 2015).

Notably, in analyzing the discourse and aesthetics of populism as securitization, Kurylo (2022) identifies a primary audience that accepts the securitizing discourses and a secondary audience crucial for disseminating them. However, in her analysis, in line with Salter (2008), the importance is placed on the setting of the securitizing moves, with a focus also on the aesthetics and the emotional connections that these moves create between the audience and the securitizing actors. Studies that combine ST and OST focus on insecurity narratives. Bonansinga has examined this by analyzing the emotions arising from different types of populism in France through a comparative analysis of the political spectrum

(Bonansinga, 2021) and a specific analysis of left-wing populism (Bonansinga, 2022). Croft also considered the role of biographical narratives and how the other is constructed in opposition to the integrity (of the biography) of the self. In his analysis, this is shown through the case of the ontological insecurity of British Muslims (2012). Määlkso, in a different vein, warns of the peril inherent in the development of OST: the necessity of satisfying ontological security for the self might be presented as a justification for the securitization of identity (2015). This consideration prompted a reaction in a theoretical discussion that highlighted the need to differentiate the analysis of identity narratives and securitization. Identity narratives do not per se must entail the securitization of others but they might also include a process of reflexivity, which is crucial to Giddens' theorizing (Browning and Joenniemi, 2016). We claim that, as a consequence, differentiating when securitization occurs alongside the exploitation of ontological (in)security is a valid analytic effort because it evidently implies a negative cycle. This particularly depends on the explicit context. In order to explain this, we need to take into account the specificities of the concept of ontological security as emerged in the field and debate of International Relations.

The reinterpretation in International Relations of Giddens' concept of ontological security (1991) stresses the crucial role of conflictive narratives in placating anxiety through coping mechanisms. As Giddens elucidates, ontological security pertains to the pursuit of safeguarding the ontological continuity of the Self. It is preserved through practices, narratives, and discourses, as well as finite relations with others that lend coherence to the "continuity of being" (1991). OST thus reflects on the consequences for collective security processes of this sense of anxiety generated by the inherent precarity of human condition (Steele, 2005; Kinnvall, 2017; Subotić, 2016; Rumelili, 2015; Steele, 2008; Herrington, 2013; Berenskötter, 2017 and 2020). The inevitability of death, as the sole certainty in life, presents humans with an existential threat that is both unknowable and unpredictable. This awareness of their own mortality compels humans to engage in a continuous quest for security. However, as Berenskötter (2020) noted, this quest to "becoming secure" can never be satisfied for humans' own condition. Therefore, it entails what he calls the *anxiety paradox*: "the tendency of reflexive humans facing the freedom of beings in time to attach themselves to constructs that provide a sense of temporal continuity" (Berenskötter, 2020: 2). Said differently, humans strive constantly to somehow anchor themselves to an idea of eternity, and this actually hinders their possibility to feel secure in their condition of intrinsic uncertainty/finiteness.

Furthermore, ontological security conceptualizes the necessity to construct "biographical continuity" in order to both endow the state's existence with specific meaning and outline its future by reinforcing its identity and purpose at both domestically and internationally. Thus, ontological insecurities have been also identified as a specific majority issue, for which we refer to the special issue introduction for more details (Prina and Carlá, forthcoming). Drawing on Heidegger's phenomenological ideas, Berenskötter (2017) posits that narratives lend meaning to the state's identity and sense of Self. National narratives grant significance to the search for "ontological security" within the form of the state, fostering a national trajectory (Subotić, 2016).

Ontological security, as per this definition, is not merely confined to "physical security", such as state sovereignty, material resources, and territorial integrity. It

underlines the aspiration to preserve a consistent sense of Self, and so it also pertains to cultural properties and thus can affect majorities' feelings about their safety as a collective (Steele, 2005; Berenskötter, 2017). As Kinnvall (2017) suggests, ontological security captures the dynamics between identity and (in)security, highlighting the importance of psychology and emotions for state behaviour in a rapidly globalizing and changing world.

The role of conflictive narratives in ontological security, as Rumelili (2015) points out, is particularly significant: "They sustain the political and social production of definite objects of fear, systems of meaning that clearly differentiate friends from enemies" (Rumelili, 2015: 2). So, the state is not actually primarily concerned with its survival, but rather the opposite: "states pursue social actions to serve self-identity needs, even when those actions compromise their physical existence (Steele, 2008; Herrington, 2013). This latter dimension shows us that the search for ontological security often becomes *paradoxical*: actors' search for ontological security can compromise their own security.

The construction of others as a threat is an example of how securitization interacts with ontological security as well as its inherent paradoxes. These practices of exclusion are a fundamental part of some national identity construction processes. In the face of ontological insecurity, individuals and governments may perceive and (re)construct the "other" as a threat and justify policies of exclusion and violence as a means of safeguarding their own identity (Neumann, 1999; Berenskötter, 2017). However, this process spirals processes of insecurities for everybody (Author 1, 2017). These others might be political or cultural adversaries, which are identified as "alters" to the group.

We posit that the far-right has advanced by strategically manipulating paradoxical claims that scapegoat marginalized groups, thereby attributing ontological insecurity to these constructed 'others.' This deliberate framing process transforms these groups into existential threats, which serves to legitimize exclusionary and securitizing social practices. In the current European political milieu, far-right ethos is steeped in traditional nationalist paradigms, which they argue fortify national identities, uphold national borders, and bolster sovereignty. This perspective stands in marked contradiction to the EU's foundational principles, which are rooted in regional integration and post-national inclusivity, eloquently expressed through its guiding motto "Unity in Diversity" (Hadj-Abdou, L., 2020). The EU, in this accounting, is also alter to the national in their discourse. Far-right parties mobilize anxieties and fears through populist, ethnocentric narratives, leading to the mobilization of nativist ideals and the spiralling securitization of others. It creates a direct socio-political confrontation in national and regional levels: the "self" against the "other" (Mudde, 2007) but also the cognition of the "desired" and the "undesired" (Author 1, 2017).

Far-right factions across the EU have blamed the institution for an alleged erosion of national authenticity. While doing so, these parties paradoxically call for a consolidation of European forces and a return to traditional values, aiming to foster prosperity within what they perceive as a white, traditional Christian civilization. This dual narrative of lost national identity and a call for European unity under traditionalist values amplifies feelings of ontological insecurity among their followers (Kinnvall, 2017). Moreover, these parties exploit this sense of insecurity to fuel their confrontational ethno-nationalist politics, which is often characterized by the "othering" of those who do not fit their narrow definition of the nation. By invoking notions of the "stranger" and the "foreigner," they draw stark lines of division within societies, heightening feelings of fear and insecurity (Mudde, 2019;

Wodak, 2022). The strategic deployment of ambiguity, paradox, and confusion emerges as a central component in the political playbook of numerous far-right movements. As suggested by Philippe Corcuff (2021), these groups engage in a form of “confusionism” - a calculated strategy designed to blur the traditional dichotomies between the political left and right, a strategy based on confusion. By fostering a climate of disarray and uncertainty, this confusionist approach complicates the task of political adversaries to construct coherent counterarguments. Similarly, scholars like Mudde (2019) and Wodak (2022) stress how far-right factions skillfully meld various ideological positions, including economic liberalism and social authoritarianism, to further the collective anxieties of majority populations. The European far-right political factions frame the perceived threat to majority status as central to their narrative. They argue that the essence of national identity, rooted in being a white Christian European majority, is under threat. This majority, they assert, is inherently entitled to reject the presence of others, including political adversaries, migrants, and cultural minorities.

Among these alterities are certain ideas about women and gender roles, which are also constructed as threats to the nation by the far-right. We consider that the analysis of this specific issue deserves an in-depth discussion; for now, we refer to the analysis of far-right movements in Spain and Italy (Author 1, 2023), which identified gender as a crucial and ambiguous theme in their narratives. Gender is concurrently blamed for attacking traditional family roles and used to justify the narrative that Muslims and migrants cannot adapt to European values (Author 1, 2023)¹. We aim to identify these methodologically through examining paradoxical claims.

In the discursive landscape of far-right politics, intriguing paradoxes emerge as nationalist factions pretend to echo broader “European values.” This discursive strategy amplifies their influence within the European Union. Far-right movements are characterized by a paradoxical amalgamation of intense nationalism and pan-European ideals—a dichotomy Mudde (2019) terms “nativist internationalism.” These parties navigate an intricate ideological terrain, oscillating between advocating for national sovereignty and endorsing a uniform European identity. Such a strategy disrupts traditional political alignments and understandings, complicating the task of their adversaries by deploying a broad net of concepts capable of attracting a wide variety of political viewpoints (Brack, 2019).

We therefore proceed to examine far-right paradoxical claims in two countries, Italy and Spain, so as to consider the discursive strategies they use to gain terrain from the exploitation of the ontological insecurity of (supposed) majorities, identified in far-right discourse as those posed by alterities. We will particularly focus on the paradoxical claims that have emerged in the past two years among their narratives.

The methodology of the analysis of paradoxes in two most similar case studies

In order to investigate how the far-right exploits the paradox of ontological security in Europe in combination with the securitization of migration, this research focuses on the two case studies of far-right parties in Spain and in Italy. Our analysis examines how the

¹ However, we hope to see more scientific developments in this sense on Spanish and Italian far-right, which are certainly necessary. Therefore, in the present work, we only consider the usage of paradoxes related to all of the previously mentioned others, including political and cultural alterities but we did not have the space to consider in depth here.

far-right employs paradoxical claims to amplify collective anxieties, contributing to ontological insecurity. Using Securitization Theory (ST), we analyze how these securitizing moves frame migration as an existential threat, creating immediate performative impacts by casting specific groups as security risks. Coupled with Ontological Security Theory (OST), we explore the enduring power of these paradoxical claims, which promise stability and continuity for collective identity amidst perceived threats. This integration of ST and OST allows us to capture both the performative and emotional dimensions of far-right discourse.

Methodologically, we go beyond a traditional discourse analysis by focusing on paradoxical claims. Instead of focusing solely on content, we examine the structure and function of claims, highlighting how they sustain ontological insecurity through ambiguity and paradoxes. To ground these theoretical insights, we analyze the cases of Spain and Italy, which provide a comparative framework for understanding how the far-right exploits ontological security and the spiraling of securitization. By creating a climate of "confusionism," these claims intensify insecurity while promising stability, resonating deeply with followers' emotional needs for identity and continuity.

To ground our theoretical insights in practical contexts, we turn to the case studies of Spain and Italy, which provide an effective comparative framework for examining the far-right's manipulation of ontological security under conditions of securitization.

Spain and Italy are two case studies that can be validly compared as they are two most similar case studies (George and Bennett, 2005). With this methodology of comparative case studies, the analysis consists in selecting two case studies which are almost identical, with the exception of one element. Italy and Spain indeed share a past history of fascism in the XX century, with Mussolini in Italy and Franco in Spain. They also both transitioned to democracy and, for both, there exists a recent growth in the far-right presence. However, the main difference is that in Italy there has been a longer presence of the far-right in the Parliament and has been in different government coalitions since the 1900ies. Currently, the far-right in Italy is leading the government, with at its head the far-right party, Fratelli d'Italia (FdI), and the leader of the party, Giorgia Meloni, is the current president of the Council of Ministers. Spain's far-right party, Vox, instead, sits at the opposition in the Spanish parliament. We will therefore consider whether this difference affects developments vis-a-vis the European Union, and particularly through the use of the ontological security paradox in the securitization of migration.

In particular, for the analysis, we will specifically focus on the usage of paradoxical claims, among their discursive strategies, in securitizing alterities, intended as what is "other", or different, from what is identified as desired. Among these, we have particularly concentrated on the paradoxes included in their claims as we consider that stressing this particular type of statements in the analysis allows us to capture how the far-right creates a climate of confusionism. A *paradox* is a statement that includes a type of logic that creates a loop which makes both one thing and its opposite *true at the same time* (Poster, 2006; Reames, 2013). The same thing both *is* and *is not* concurrently, as in the famous Heraclitean paradox: "The path up and down is one and the same" (Barnes, 1987: 103).

We consider that looking at these types of statements can empirically elucidate how the far-right uses such paradoxes to create a climate of confusionism that contributes to the paradox of ontological security. We therefore scrutinize all those paradoxical claims that have emerged in the far-right parties in Italy and Spain in the past two years (2022-2023).

We selected this timeframe as it offers one empirical advantage: it allows us to consider both parties' most recent electoral program and related narratives, as it includes the most recent electoral campaigns that have taken place in both countries, in Italy on 25 September 2022 and in Spain on 23 July 2023.

The analysis aims to examine the role of the far-right in exploiting the ontological security paradox in combination with the climate of securitization of others by specifically creating a climate of "confusionism" through paradoxical claims.

The findings on the paradoxes in the far-right in Italy and Spain and the consequences for the EU's ontological security

As argued, by examining the main discursive strategies from 2022 and 2023, we find that Vox in Spain and Fratelli d'Italia in Italy exhibit striking similarities, making them valuable comparative case studies. However, crucial distinctions also emerge. A significant difference is the continuous presence of far-right parties in Italy, which does not parallel the situation in Spain. Despite both countries sharing the common experience of 20th-century fascist regimes, their far-right political histories diverge notably.

In Spain, a far-right party has officially emerged only recently with Vox, and has never led the country, although it has been involved in some local governments. In Italy, instead, several far-right governments have been in the coalitions of parties leading the country before. Indeed, despite the official condemnation of fascism and the formal declaration of attempts of restoring or making apologies for the fascist party as unlawful in the Italian Constitution signed at the end of the Second World War, the Italian political spectrum shows a continued presence of far-right political parties. Notably, these are the Movimento Sociale Italiano (established in 1946), Fiamma Tricolore (Tricolor Flame founded in 1991), Alleanza Nazionale (as a political force splitting from the Movimento Social Italiano in 1995 and then ending into Berlusconi's coalition Il Popolo della Libertà), CasaPound (split from Fiamma Tricolore and founded in 2003 and which, as of 2022, only remains in the form of a political movement), Forza Nuova (formed in 1997), La Lega (founded as Lega Nord in 1991, and transformed into La Lega in 2017) and, finally, the recent Fratelli d'Italia (created in 2012). The country has already been led by the far-right in the past two decades, with Forza Italia and Alleanza Nazionale forming a coalition in Berlusconi's governments and with La Lega. In particular, in Italy as a consequence of the electoral results in 2022, Fratelli d'Italia has formed the new Italian government together with La Lega and Forza Italia.

Both in Italy and in Spain, the far-right share that it has never condemned their respective nations' fascist and authoritarian past. So, in both cases, their political situation presents an identity paradox: in these parties' narratives they both *are* and *are not* fascist at the same time. Giorgia Meloni, current leader of FdI, leads the Council of Ministers in Italy, while her fellow party member and former party leader, Ignazio La Russa, son of an official representative of Benito Mussolini's government in Sicily during fascism (Albertaino 2010), is currently President of the Senate. Ignazio La Russa has never rejected fascism, officially holds a collection of Mussolini's busts (Corriere della Sera, 2018) and he has reproduced the right-hand fascist salute in the Parliament, on 13 September 2017ⁱ. Giorgia Meloni's jubilee, when La Russa was elected on 13 October 2022 as president of

the Senate of the Italian Parliament, did not pass unnoticed in the Italian public debate (La Repubblica, 2022).

As a confirmation of Meloni's *unproblematic* connivence with fascism, she made a joke in interview in which she had left her right hand as a public salute, and then she changed to the left hand saying: "Better this one!"ⁱⁱ. The fact of joking on such a delicate issue shows her negligence of it as a true problem and *banalizes* it, in line with what Askanius and Keller (2021) illustrate with their analysis of fascist memes. In addition, by considering it further, it also reveals to go much beyond this banalization: both institutional authorities, Giorgia Meloni and Ignazio La Russa, have performed the Roman salute in public occasions close to the date of 12 September, which is a crucial date for fascists in Italy. September 12, 1943 is the date in which Nazi soldiers rescued Mussolini from his imprisonment that had started in July of the same year (Viganó 1991). It is also the date that Gabriele D'Annunzio (an Italian poet and fascist official) marched on Fiume (the Italian name for the town of Rijeka, in Croatia), which is a crucial part of the Italian fascist narratives (Viganó 1991). Therefore, when Meloni and La Russa perform the Roman salute, respectively on September 12 and 13, they are sending a message to fascist people, saluting and celebrating a very specific date and event of absolute historical relevance for the Italian fascists.

Meloni's joke on the fascist salute clearly illustrates the potent usage of paradoxes in politics. By joking about the fascist salute, Meloni is both performing and not performing it, creating confusionism on the topic. For those who are fascist, she has actually made the fascist salute in a public press interview on the very crucial date of September 12. For those who claim she is not fascist, she was *only* joking. She is performing for the "ontological security" of fascism. The gesture is entirely wrapped in this logic. It is ensuring fascism's existence and continuity and she is also demonstrating to the fascist voters that officially fascism is always under existential threat, as even she, as in the role of President of the Council, does not have the power to perform it openly but has to perform and pretend it as a joke. The impossibility to be fascist (because of the law) and the reality of being fascist in the country political life, is an exemplary use of the combination of ontological anxiety and securitization in a paradoxical claim.

Emerging later than its counterparts in Italy, Spain in 2019 was denoted as "the end of the European exception" when in the national elections of that year, Vox secured a significant portion of seats its representation more than doubled in the subsequent November 2019 elections (Rubio-Pueyo, 2019). The Spanish far-right party notably neither rejects nor condemns Franco's regime. Upon dissecting speeches and statements made by Vox's key figures, a pattern emerges that demonstrates a selective and somewhat apologetic view towards Francoism. For instance, on September 9, 2020, Santiago Abascal made a statement during the Plenary Session of the Congress of Deputies declaring the current government as "the worst Government of our country in 80 years"ⁱⁱⁱ. Such a statement implicitly trivializes the harsh realities of Franco's dictatorship, inadvertently framing it in a less damning light than the present democratic regime. Similarly, Vox's secretary-general, Javier Ortega Smith-Molina, claimed, "there were elections during Francoism"^{iv}. Although technically accurate, this assertion is misleading due to the lack of genuine democratic procedure and widespread electoral manipulation that marked Franco's regime. The claim is also using a paradox to create confusionism. It is in fact true that there

were elections during Franco's regime. However, the fact that there were elections does not render Francoism democratic. The paradoxical nature of these claims contributes to the confusing rhetoric we previously highlighted both in our theoretical framework and in the details of our methodological procedures. Ortega Smith-Molina's refusal to categorically condemn Francoism indicates a lack of acknowledgment of the horrific human rights abuses perpetrated during Franco's rule^v. Similarly, Vox deputy Francisco José Carreras' portrayal of Franco's era as a time of "true reconciliation with gestures of harmony"^v sidesteps the systematic violence and repression of the time, painting an oversimplified and idealistic picture of "peace". Vox's rhetoric displays a paradoxical and undeniable tolerance, even an implicit endorsement, of Francoism while downplaying the regime's widespread atrocities. This discourse positions Vox as a potential ideological successor to Francoism and aligns it with a stance of denial regarding the crimes committed under the dictatorship.

However, it does not identify a securitization of the theme of the ontological security of fascism, like in the Italian case. Vox denies the crime committed by Francoism, its atrocities, but does not refer to it reminding continually the fact or the possibility of its non-existence in the present and the future. It does not securitize it with military or war memories. It shows a supposed grandiosity through the imperial nostalgia but not through the presence of threats to its being. The difference in relation to the historical past of the two countries influencing the destiny and the narrative of their far-right ideologies can be detected in the narratives about Imperialism and liberalism.

Italy's far-right, still today, presents a clear anti-Imperialist stance *vis a vis* the United States. An example is Meloni's very peculiar way to celebrate Liberation Day, which, from the year 1946, commemorates when the Italian partisans along with their allies led by the United States liberated the country from fascism on 25 April 1945². In Italy, every year the country celebrates Liberation Day with a series of commemorations, including the institutional visit to the Altare della Patria -a national monument that Italian institutional authorities use(d) to visit on Liberation Day-, a free concert in Rome, and a number of other public events everywhere across the country. As it is reported in a national newspaper and can be seen in a video it published of the event (La Repubblica, 2023), Meloni went to the Altare della Patria to "commemorate" the day with Ignazio La Russa, the afore mentioned collector of Mussolini's busts and currently president of the Senate, but she refused to climb the Altare with the President of the Republic, Sergio Mattarella, to leave the laurel crown on it. She also requested not to play the Italian Mameli anthem, another national symbol of liberation and the rejection of fascism, as she claimed that this would be a "communist symbol", as in her narratives the Partisans are called communists (La Repubblica, 2023). The paradox once again is used as a case of ontological security for the people, this time to be secure from both the liberal and the communist threat, that are associated as allies in this rhetorical report of an historical event which saw the United States supporting the Italian Partisans. This is a way to create confusion and historically decontextualize the Second World War antifascist alliances from today's politics and Meloni's alignment with the US. In the Italian far-right discourse, all those who fought the

² The Italian Lieutenant legislative decree of 22 April 1946 reads: "In Celebration of the complete liberation of the Italian territory, the day April 25, 1946 is declared national holiday" (TDA from the Italian "A celebrazione della totale liberazione del territorio italiano, il 25 aprile 1946 è dichiarato festa nazionale").

Fascist regime are depicted as either Imperialists (the US) or Communists (the Partisans), it is to say as enemies who “complot” against the autonomy of the Italian nation. These are also identified therefore as alterities who threaten the nation, securitizing ontological anxieties. They reject Liberation Day as a commemoration of what they present as an historical intervention of the United States against the political autonomy of Italy and, at the same time, its joining forces with the “communism” of Partisans. This happens despite her current alignment with US politics. In this way, Meloni uses a catch-all strategy to win both the moderates (who would align with the US) and the extremist, far-right voters who are in strong opposition to the US for the historical role it has had in supporting the Partisans to rule out the Fascist regime.

Spain’s far-right political movement does not have such an anti-imperialist stance vis-a-vis the United States, since suffer from imperial nostalgia. Spain experienced a significant shift in its global status when it lost its main colonies, the Philippines and Cuba, to independence at the end of the 19th century. This event forced Spain to recalibrate its national standing, both regionally and globally. Spain cultivated an imperial nostalgia following the independence of Cuba and the Philippines in 1898 (Harrison & Hoyle, 2000). The far-right political ideology in Spain is deeply ingrained in this imperial nostalgia, crafting narratives that emphasize today the “unity” of the Spanish Crown (Casals, 2020). Santiago Abascal, the leader of Vox, declared, “We like *Reconquistas*.”^{vi}

However, in this specific case, we can identify a securitization of ontological anxieties connected with issues of alterities only in the case of Muslim migrants and not all migrants. The term “Reconquista” refers to the seven centuries-long conflict between the Christian Kingdoms and the Muslim Moors for control of the Iberian Peninsula (722-1492). This rhetoric draws a parallel between the current moment and the legendary battles that are believed to have formed Spain through the expulsion of the Arab kingdoms (Esteve-Del-Valle & López, 2022). Thus, it is a rhetoric that combines the concepts of an anti-Islamic war and past imperial conquests. Vox stokes fear about the potential Islamization of southern Spain, epitomized by scenarios such as the re-conversion of the Cordoba cathedral into a mosque and the imposition of veils on women. Anti-Islamic sentiment, thus, emerges as a key strand of Vox’s popular appeal, alongside xenophobia in relation to immigrants particularly in Andalusia. However, it is precisely this Islamic history that forms the core of Andalusian identity (and beyond), contributing significantly to the richness of Spain. This heritage is often highlighted to emphasize the uniqueness of Spanish national identity internationally, as well as its political potential due to its proximity and connections with North African and Muslim countries. So, the far-right reflects the paradox of the ontological security, where the *impossibility to be* joins forces with *the fact of being*, and the issue is securitized. In Vox’s narratives of the Reconquista, the paradoxical claims that connect securitization processes with ontological anxieties become even stronger with the discourse related to immigration.

Further, the Iberian sphere is built on the foundation of Hispanity, the political representation of a Spanish ethos accompanied by a nationalist mythology. While the myth of the civilizing, beneficent Empire is central, it is linked to the equally founding myth of the Reconquista (Garcia Sanjuán, 2023). Shaped throughout the 19th century, in parallel with the construction of the modern Spanish nation, the Reconquista is a Christian mythological narrative designed to legitimize the authority of liberal revolutions against

the sources of traditional power, notably the Church and the Crown. Once anchored in Spanish historiography, the Reconquest became an ideological weapon to combat Spain's enemies, both external and internal. In this, Franco is said to have led a new Reconquista against Spain's Second Republic, just as Vox launched its 2019 general election campaign in Covadonga, the starting point of the so-called Reconquista in the eighth century (Cuenca, 2023). What is more, as a Christian mythology, the Reconquista also appeals to other far-right forces in Europe: witness the name of Éric Zemmour's party, whose party is just the French translation of the myth: *Reconquête*, or Viktor Orban's assertion at the 2023 CPAC (Conservative Political Action Conference, the International of the far right) in Budapest that the Reconquista began in Europe (CPAC, 2023).

Vox effectively exploits the mystical narrative of the Reconquista to reinforce their political message, portraying the historical conflict as a symbolic battle against contemporary issues like immigration and the presence of Muslims in Spain, thereby evoking a sense of historical continuity and urgency, suggesting that the same vigilance and unity displayed in the past are needed to protect Spanish identity today, and tapping into deep-seated cultural memories and fears so to legitimize their anti-immigrant and anti-Islamic stances as a defense of national sovereignty and cultural heritage.

Instead, an example of a clear securitization of alterities, framed as an ontological security issue, is evident in Vox's xenophobic principles outlined in the party's presidential electoral program during the 2019 campaign. In this document, immigration was highlighted as the second most important issue, following closely behind defence, security, and borders. Under the section on immigration, Vox advanced numerous issues, among them two significant measures: the deportation of illegal immigrants back to their countries of origin and the deportation of immigrants who are in Spain legally but have either reoffended with minor crimes or committed a serious offence (Vox, 2018). The party's perspective on defence, security, and borders further reveals their hardline stance. Vox advocated for the strengthening of Spain's borders, even suggesting the construction of an impregnable wall in Ceuta and Melilla. It also demanded that the police and armed forces be provided with all necessary resources—both material and human—to effectively safeguard the borders, accompanied by the appropriate legal protections. In an additional reflection of its nativist approach, Vox proposed the publication of crime statistics data disaggregated by nationality and origin (Vox, 2018). This encapsulates the party's overall doctrine, which is rooted in a stringent and exclusionary concept of national identity and a clear securitization of migration. Furthermore, a pronounced use of threat and fear rhetoric is a notable feature of the discourse of the Spanish far-right party. For example, Abascal's speech at the Spanish Congress of Deputies, categorizes migrants as "the enemies of the Spanish" while implying they "assault our borders", "intend to ruin us", "divide the country" and "sow panic in the streets"^{vii}.

Furthermore, Abascal associates an association between immigration and the notions of crime and insecurity, proposing a "close relationship between the security of the Spanish and the pull effect and the open-door policies"^{viii}. This reasoning echoes a common stereotype embedded within anti-immigrant and anti-Islamic rhetoric that links immigration with crime and insecurity. Dehumanization is a recurring motif in Vox's propaganda and rhetoric. The depiction of migrants as "the enemies of the Spanish people" serves to divest these individuals of their humanity, effectively simplifying the task of

inciting fear or aversion towards them. Vox promotes a policy of prioritizing and socially privileging national natives, encapsulated in slogans such as "In Spain, Spaniards first"^{ix} "Spaniards should have priority access to social aid"^x "Spain first"^{xi} and "Spaniards will be first"^{xii}. Vox posits that a nation owes its primary obligation to its "children," who are not just its rightful residents, but also its proprietors. On this, Vox's rhetoric aligns seamlessly with that of its Italian counterparts. The nation is envisaged as a house, rightfully owned by an ethnic group, and can only be occupied as a "guest" or "visitor" by those who do not originally belong to the native group.

Nonetheless, the Spanish far-right notably presents another paradoxical discourse around migration, if seen in its perspective towards migrants from Latin American countries. This distinction can be attributed to the concept of "Hispanidad" or Hispanicity and the idea of the "Iberosphere", an embodiment of imperial nostalgia that shapes attitudes towards immigration. "Historically, the "Hispanidad" alliance connects Spain with Latin America, manifesting a sense of shared heritage and culture that traces back to Spain's colonial era" (Valdes 2001). The construction of a feeling of greatness based on the 500 million speakers of the Spanish language as a result of colonialism is part of the imperial nostalgia across political ideologies and is acute among far-right movements, and this has built a sharp difference between Spanish speaking immigrants and those having other backgrounds. The ideologue of Vox modernizes a historical nationalism that intertwines Spain's various mythical episodes, as previously discussed. Additionally, the Spanish far-right political party exploits the works of the "Generación del 98," a group of intellectuals like Miguel de Unamuno, who emerged post-1898 Spanish-American War, critiqued Spain's decline, and sought national regeneration. These intellectuals, witnessing the disintegration of the Spanish Empire and perceiving a decadent Spain, contribute to Vox's ideology. They emphasized reconstructing ties with Spain's former imperial territories, promoting a direct imperialist vision now appropriated by Vox (Cuenca, 2023).

This perspective, which exhibits a preference for citizens from the "Iberosphere", can be described in terms of "Hispanist Ethnicity" or "Ethnic Hispanism" (Fernández-Vázquez and Lerín, 2022). This viewpoint essentially entails an expansion of native ethnicity under conditions of subordination, harking back to the myth of the empire(s), and postulating a certain level of compatibility. This alliance has influenced Vox's stance on immigration, marking a significant difference with Italian far-right movements, such as the Lega Nord and Fratelli d'Italia, that are typically more exclusionary towards non-European immigrants without exception. Vox, contrary to many of its far-right counterparts across Europe, is not radically against immigration from Latin American countries, provided certain conditions are met. Spain's nostalgic connection to its former colonies seems to have fostered a degree of tolerance within Vox's anti-immigration rhetoric. As an illustration of ethnic Hispanism and the "Iberosphere", this assertion made by Santiago Abascal during a public gathering in Gran Canaria in 2018, encapsulates Vox's distinct viewpoint on the Latin American region: "It is not the same for an immigrant to come from a brotherly Latin American country, with the same culture, the same language, and the same worldview, as immigration coming from Islamic countries"^{xiii}. This viewpoint reflects the enduring influence of Spain's imperial past on its present-day political landscape and illustrates the usage of paradoxes by Vox. The "brotherhood" expressed by sharing the same language is projected into a "common" cultural heritage but can nevertheless also

develop forms of discrimination towards immigrants based on skin colour, “mixed” cultural origins or bilingualism when immigrants speak Quechua, Guarani or other indigenous American languages.

On the topic of migration, Italian Far-right politics also presents a very intricate discourse, illustrating further paradoxical claims. The country has gained a lot from immigration in recent years, both politically, for the leverage it provides to all transit countries in engaging with the EU (Author 1, 2022a; Webb 2022; Seeberg and Zardo 2022), and culturally and economically (Author 1, 2017). Giorgia Meloni’s declarations become very ambiguous when the country witnessed the arrival of hundreds of thousands of migrants in the first ten days of September 2023. In a declaration released in a video at the time^{xiv}, Giorgia Meloni claims that she will create more room in “Centri per i Rimpatri”, expulsion centres which have prison-like conditions (Author 1, 2022b). Meloni states in these declarations that those who do not have rights to claim asylum will be returned to their countries. She never says that she will stop irregular migration, but she warns migrants to avoid irregular channels of migration, as smugglers take a lot of money for travels that are very unsafe. However, one year before, in August 2022, in a video that was part of her electoral campaign^{xv}, she announced that, differently from previous progressive Italian governments, she would stop the illegal arrival of migrants with the use of the military. In particular, she announced the use of naval blockage in collaboration with Northern African States, following a strategy that she claims was first proposed by the EU in 2017. Therefore, Meloni, in her narratives, concurrently *blames* the EU while she uses it to validate her political approach. Once more, it is possible to identify that she is using paradoxical claims so as to generate confusion. The usage of ontological insecurity together with the securitization of migration is exploited again. At the end of this promotional video, she says that she “will not allow smugglers, human traffickers and those who wants to destabilize our Nation to manage migration flows”^{xvi}. The securitization of migration controls becomes entirely blatant in this message. She talks of migration in military terms openly in a recently released video^{xvii}, with a discourse that insists on “the *defence* of national borders”, depicting the arrival of migrants as an attack to the national territory. This defence of national border is at the same time a defence of the European borders in her narratives, but also paradoxically a way to defend the Italian nation from the European Union, which supposedly for Fratelli d’Italia takes advantages from making sure that migrants reach Italy and cannot move further within Europe. Meloni paradoxically represents “Italy” as concurrently the defender of Europe and, for the very same reason, exploited by the European Union^{xviii}. Such examples of paradoxes in addition to create confusion on the topic, and therefore to gather votes from different sides of the political spectrum, they also confirm the importance to examine the roles of narratives in the spiralling of the securitization of migration (Author 1, 2017; Author 1, 2022a; Author 1 and Léonard, 2023). Such a situation is evident in the increasing usage of military terminology, in both Meloni’s and Abascal’s narratives that connect migration and crime, in the typical nexus identified in the literature of the securitization (Huysmans 2006; Bourbeau 2011).

The ideology of Abascal’s party in relation to the EU might at first examination seem to set it apart from other far-right movements across Europe. It would appear to align more closely with the neoliberal economic principles of Partido Popular (PP) and

Ciudadanos, two of Spain's mainstream conservative parties. This is most evident in its economic stances on public spending cuts and taxation. While many far-right parties across Europe have condemned the austerity measures introduced post-2010, associating them with a general rejection of EU institutions, Vox has upheld a conventional conservative economic line. Vox has particularly emphasized orthodox tax policies (Applebaum, 2022). However, it is of paramount importance to recognize that Abascal has actively adopted and utilized the standard discourses of far-right politics, notably placing the European Union in the crosshairs as a prominent facilitator of immigration. Moreover, he has expressed considerable apprehension over what he sees as the gradual attrition of Spain's sovereignty under the influence of EU policies and mandates. Abascal has made his stance towards the EU distinctly clear, asserting, "We do not want a federal Europe in which all decisions are made in Brussels" (Osuna and Rama, 2021, p.2). Hence, while Vox maintains adherence to specific economic ideologies that are analogous to those of other right-wing parties, Vox is in sync with the larger narrative of the European far-right through its manifestation of Eurosceptic tendencies, often framed in securitised ways. Abascal frames these views as a primary threat to Spain's national security, exemplifying the complex interplay between far-right discourse and Spanish domestic politics. Despite Vox's seemingly more liberal and open stance, they harbor a Eurosceptic essence and a retrograde view aligned with the Francoist slogan "Dios, patria y familia" ("God, country, and family"). This position underscores the party's deep roots in Francoist discourse, emphasizing the preservation of Spain and its values from perceived European corruption.

As it can be portrayed in Vox's 2018 political agenda for the presidential elections of 2019, they explicitly say that the EU should be a collaboration of sovereign nations, respecting each other's boundaries to achieve common objectives efficiently and fairly. According to Vox, this requires a clear delineation of the roles of common institutions, a principle often overstepped by the EU's Court of Justice. In addition, Vox affirms that current globalist agendas risk converting the EU into an enormous bureaucratic structure detached from member states' interests, potentially undermining Europe's historical, traditional, and Christian identity. (Vox, 2018). In this regard, Vox's 2018 manifesto encapsulates the core themes typical of far-right ideologies, namely national sovereignty, anti-globalization, cultural preservation, and criticism of bureaucratic elites. Within the broader European context, Vox, under Santiago Abascal's leadership, has firmly established itself as an integral part of the European far-right, aligning with analogous parties and figures within the European political milieu. This is evidenced by the party's co-signing of a declaration alongside leaders such as Hungary's Viktor Orbán, Marine Le Pen of France, Matteo Salvini, representatives of Flemish nationalists, Giorgia Meloni of Fratelli d'Italia, and André Ventura of Portugal's Chega party. In this shared statement, the signatories voice their opposition to the perceived "globalism of the Brussels elites", alleging that these elites guide the EU in a manner detrimental to the sovereignty and wellbeing of its member states (Calleja, 2021). Thus, the EU is also considered a threat to national sovereignty and thus a securitization of ontological anxieties is evident. Moreover, multiple remarks by Jorge Buxadé, a VOX member and EU deputy, elucidate the party's overarching critique of the EU and its adherence to the nationalist and Christian foundations of Spanish far-right politics. For instance, Buxadé contends that Vox is battling "against a legion of bureaucrats who want to rob us of the freedom of our nations and the

primacy of our constitutions" (Vox, 2020). In another instance, during a speech in the EU Parliament, he questioned the EU's inclusive stance, rhetorically asking if, "by virtue of being inclusive, are they going to exclude the Christians of Europe? Replace us with peaceful jihadists?"^{xviii}.

Before concluding, Table 1 provides a summary of all these complex findings of the paradoxical claims in far-right parties in Italy and Spain.

Table 1: Summaries of findings on the paradoxical claims in far-right narratives in the years 2022 and 2023		
Paradoxes	Italy	Spain
Fascism: they concurrently are and are not fascist	Current Italian Government Coalition supposedly conservative but: - La Russa's Roman Salute in Parliament on 13 Sept 2017. - Meloni's joke on the Roman Salute in a press meeting on 12 Sept 2023. Both are performed close to the date of 12 September 1943, the day the Nazis rescued Mussolini from his imprisonment that started on July 25th 1943. A securitization is performed in combination with ontological (in)security.	Vox's rhetoric paradoxically tolerates, even implicitly endorses, Francoism while minimizing its atrocities, positioning the party as an ideological heir in denial of the dictatorship's crimes. - Santiago Abascal's declaration on Sanchez's government: "The worst government of our country in the past 80 years" refers therefore to Franco's government as better than the current one. - Javier Ortega Smith: "There were elections during Francoism" Francisco José Carrera: Franco's era as a time of "true reconciliation with gestures of harmony". No securitization is performed in combination with ontological (in)security.
National Identity and Imperialism	Against the historical role of the US in 1945 as allies of the Italian Partisans, who are identified by FdI as Communists: - Liberation Day celebration: Giorgia Meloni and Ignazio La Russa refuse to commemorate the Altare della Patria and to play the Italian Hymn as they claim it symbolizes Communism. A securitization is performed in combination with ontological (in)security.	The far-right political ideology in Spain is deeply ingrained in this imperial nostalgia, crafting narratives that emphasize today the "unity" of the Spanish Crown. - Santiago Abascal (2021): "We like Reconquistas". No securitization is performed in combination with ontological (in)security.

Migration and the European Union	Giorgia Meloni claims that she, and the ministries of her government, act in order to defend Europe but concurrently she blames the EU for not helping on migrants, while she uses the EU as an endorsement of her government's politics. - Giorgia Meloni's speech on 27 June 2023 against the EU Commissioner for Human Rights for the alleged challenges that the Commissioner poses to Italy on migration, while she concurrently says that her policies on migration reproduce and are inspired by EU politics. securitization is performed in combination with ontological (in)security.	Vox's patriotic Anti-Immigration, and Islamophobic discourses happens concurrently with imperial nostalgia that welcomes Hispanic migrants from Latin America: - Santiago Abascal (2018): "It is not the same for an immigrant to come from a brotherly Latin American country, with the same culture, the same language, and the same worldview, as immigration coming from Islamic countries". - Jorge Buxadé (2021): "In the name of inclusion, are they planning to exclude Europe's Christians? Replace us with peaceful jihadists?" A securitization is performed in combination with ontological (in)security only towards Muslim migrants.
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Conclusions

With the analysis provided here, it becomes evident that both Italy and Spain, despite their differences in incorporating formal far-right political parties within their respective parliaments, exhibit a lasting presence of far-right ideologies. This presence signifies the existence of a latent potential for the expansion and consolidation of far-right sentiments in these countries. Vox, despite the atrocities committed during the Francoist regime in Spain, avoids explicitly condemning this era of Spanish history. It seems to focus on emphasizing a sense of unity and national pride that nostalgically recalls an image of a strong, undivided Spain under Franco. Similarly, Fratelli d'Italia in Italy refrains from outright condemning the country's fascist past under Mussolini. Their discursive strategies tend to glorify the notion of a unified and powerful Italy, subtly echoing the nationalistic ethos of the fascist period. In both cases, these far-right parties do not overtly endorse the oppression of their countries' pasts and concurrently they perform fascist symbols, thus presenting the ontological security paradox of concurrently "being" and "not being" fascists. However, only Fratelli d'Italia presents a process of securitization of the fascist identity. They exploit the ontological security paradox of being and the impossibility to be, such as for example with the use of fascist symbolism. Instead, Vox does not currently use strategies to securitize the Francoist/fascist identity, while Fratelli d'Italia clearly does so.

However, both far-right parties in these two countries capitalize on the sentiments of national unity and strength associated with these periods and on the perceptions of threats posed by what they identify as alterities. The Italian far-right exploits the ontological security paradox and securitization in several different ways, mainly the ontological (in)security of their national identity, with the creation of external threats to the nation. In Italy, Meloni and La Russa concurrently reject Liberation Day as a commemoration of the intervention of the United States against the political autonomy of Italy and, at the same time, its joining forces with the "communism" of Partisans. In contrast, in the case of Spain, these paradoxical claims stand in the rhetoric of the Reconquista, the Spanish imperialist own history. Abascal, Vox's leader, establishes an association between immigration and the notions of crime and insecurity only in the case of Muslim migrants, accusing them of worsening street violence, but he concurrently uses the rhetoric of the Reconquista and this sense of Hispanidad to restore the greatness of the Kingdom of Spain. So, Latin American migrants are included in this Hispanidad and cannot be securitised. In this way, the confusion created serves the scope to gain support from all sides. In Italy, Meloni's discourse on migration is also deeply ingrained with a catch-all strategy: migration is economically necessary and politically useful to leverage with and within the EU, but it also becomes the reason for strong criticism towards the EU and to claim the need to defend both the national borders and (White Supremacist) Europeaness. This is indeed where the alliance between Abascal and Meloni reaches its climax. For both countries, a crucial usage of paradoxes is related to issues of national identity, migration, and Europeaness, framed in terms of ontological security issues. In such a way, the Italian and the Spanish far-right political movements of Vox and Fratelli d'Italia share paradoxical claims contributing to what has been called a "spiralling process of the securitization of migration" (Author 1, 2017 and 2022; Author 1 and Léonard, 2023) when their racial and cultural stigmatization

of migrants and refugees takes place. This happens alongside an anti-EU resentment related to the (supposed) EU inclusive agenda that clashes with their anti-immigration policies and paradoxically endorses the far-right policies by affirming that it follows the EU's strategy. Thus, far-right movements are characterized by a paradoxical amalgamation of intense nationalism and pan-European ideals - a dichotomy Mudde (2019) terms as "nativist internationalism". These parties navigate an intricate ideological terrain, oscillating between advocating for national sovereignty and endorsing a uniform European identity. Such a strategy disturbs traditional political alignments and understandings, thereby complicating the task of their adversaries and deploying a catch-all net of concepts able to attract a very large variety of political viewpoints (Brack, 2019). The idealized vision of a homogeneous European identity propagated by far-right parties is a conception that neither aligns with the historical realities nor the contemporary realities of a diverse Europe. Through the combination of OST and securitization theories in our theoretical framework, we were able to identify how paradoxes are used by the far-right in Italy and Spain to discursively exploit ontological anxieties and socially construct political and cultural alterities as threats to what is identified as core national. However, Vox does not always show a combination of both techniques. This study demonstrates that both merging and discerning the two theories—and identifying their discursive practices in the field—provide valid analytical insights and advancements in understanding complex political strategies in innovative ways. However, this study does not encompass the full spectrum of alterities identified by far-right movements, particularly in regard to gender. The exploration of gendered alterities, which far-right ideologies often position as incompatible with national identity while simultaneously using them to distinguish from "uncivilized others" (Author 1, 2023), warrants further investigation. Future research should thus prioritize these gendered dimensions to fully understand their role within far-right discursive strategies. Moreover, it is imperative to expand the scope of studies examining the role of paradoxes in international politics. We contend that the insights gained from analyzing ontological security and securitization processes are applicable beyond the immediate context of majority ontological securities, offering valuable perspectives across various domains of political analysis.

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